



Fresh threat: Newly promoted Diamond Harbour, which has made strong investments with the likes of Bright Enobhakare and Luka Majcen, will look to continue its rapid rise and disrupt the established sides.

DEBASISH BHADURI

promotion to Inter Kashi. Churchill will instead continue its battle in court, having taken the case against the AIFF to the Delhi High Court.

Due to the delayed start, the league will return to the format it incorporated in post-Covid times between 2020 and 2022. The 10 teams will play out a single-leg round-robin stage before the top six teams qualify for the championship round to fight for the title, while the bottom four teams will have a scrap

to avoid relegation. The winner of the I-League will earn promotion to the ISL, but the relegation spots have been cut from two to one.

Usual suspects Gokulam Kerala, Real Kashmir, Rajasthan United, Dempo and Sreenidi Deccan will aim to make the most of this curtailed season to win the championship and earn the coveted move up to the ISL.

Newly promoted Diamond Harbour, which has made strong investments with the likes of Bright Enobhakare and Luka Majcen, will look to continue its rapid rise and disrupt the established sides. Aizawl, Chanmari and Shillong Lajong, which have not made any overseas signings, will have a tough time trying to stay up.

Arshad is confident that the self-funding approach adopted by

the clubs will benefit Indian football.

"All of them have taken this soulless responsibility saying, 'We can't kill football. We can't kill the passion of 1.4 billion people.' So they said we'll cut ourselves to the bone and come and fund it.

"Previously, some club owners, both in the ISL and the I-League, did not have the balance sheet to support it. That led to a virtual systematic collapse of the marketing rights, media rights and sponsorship value at the central level and at the ground level.

"So now, once there is seriousness from both the ISL and the I-League club owners to come in and, with our own money, make the league much better and bigger, then we'll attract investment," said an optimistic Arshad.